

Maybe Put On Real Pants

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Essay

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A funny, slightly tired plea for young adults to rediscover ordinary maturity, basic decency, and maybe actual pants.

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I saw a grown man at the gas station the other morning wearing pajama pants, Crocs, a hoodie that looked like it had lost a fight with a laundry basket, and a facial expression that suggested other customers had personally betrayed him.

Now, to be fair, I was at a gas station in the morning, so I was not exactly dressed for the cover of *Gentlemen's Quarterly* myself. I was probably wearing jogging pants that had seen better government administrations and a shirt selected mostly because it was near the top of the pile. So I am not coming at this as some polished ambassador of human excellence.

But there is a difference between casual and surrendered.

That is the thing I keep noticing. Somewhere along the line, a whole lot of public life started to look like everyone had collectively given up, but still wanted to be treated like royalty while doing it. Pajama pants in the cereal aisle. Slippers in restaurants. Blankets wrapped around people in airports like they are exhausted Civil War soldiers awaiting evacuation. Hair doing things that hair, in a civilized society, should at least have to explain. And faces buried in phones so completely that making eye contact with another human being now feels like asking them to complete a mortgage application in Latin.

I know every generation complains about the one after it. That is practically required by law. I am sure some guy in 1987 saw me walking around in zoomba pants (thanks Mom!), a Hypercolor shirt, and enough hair gel to threaten local wildlife and thought, "Well, civilization had a good run." He may not have been entirely wrong. The 80s and 90s were not some golden age of maturity. We had mullets, slap bracelets, Beavis and Butt-Head, and adults who smoked in restaurants like indoor air was just a suggestion.

We were idiots too.

But we were expected to grow out of it.

That expectation seems to be where things have shifted. When I was growing up, you could be awkward, lazy, sarcastic, moody, dramatic, and convinced your parents were the only people in North America too stupid to understand real life. That was called being fifteen. It was annoying, but at least it had a shelf life. Adults tolerated some of it because they knew adolescence was a temporary construction zone. There were orange cones everywhere. Nobody enjoyed driving through it, but eventually the road was supposed to open back up.

Now I look around and see a strange extended adolescence that has moved well into adulthood and brought snacks.

And again, I am trying to be fair. There are plenty of young people who work hard, show up on time, take care of themselves, serve others, hold down jobs, raise kids, love their families, and carry more pressure than they probably should. I know some of them. I admire them. This is not about every millennial or every Gen Z young adult. Whole generations cannot be stuffed into one cardboard box and labeled "fragile, do not shake," no matter how tempting that may be after spending ten minutes on TikTok.

But there is a pattern.

It shows up in small things first. The inability to greet someone without mumbling into a screen. The refusal to make eye contact with a cashier, a teacher, a coworker, a neighbor, or anyone else who has the audacity to exist

in three dimensions. The habit of treating basic interaction like emotional labor. The way ordinary correction gets received as trauma, ordinary disagreement becomes violence, and ordinary responsibility gets punted downfield like a fourth-and-long.

At some point, being uncomfortable became the same thing as being harmed.

That is a problem.

Because life is uncomfortable. Work is uncomfortable. Marriage is uncomfortable. Parenting is uncomfortable. Having to call the insurance company and explain that no, you did not receive the form, and yes, you checked the portal, and no, the portal does not count as a functioning human relationship, is uncomfortable. But we still have to do it. Adults do uncomfortable things all the time. Not because we enjoy them. We do them because nobody else is coming.

That was one of the unspoken lessons of growing up in the 80s and 90s. Nobody was especially impressed with your discomfort. If you were nervous about ordering your own food, your dad would stand there and say, “Tell her what you want,” while you stared at the menu board like it contained nuclear launch codes. If you forgot your homework, you got a zero, maybe a lecture, and then you learned, at least temporarily, that paper had to move from backpack to desk in a timely fashion.

Was all of that perfect? Absolutely not. Some adults were too harsh. Some kids needed help and did not get it. Some families used “toughen up” as a lazy substitute for love. I am not trying to bring back emotional neglect with a side of canned green beans.

But there was something useful inside the old expectations. You were supposed to become more capable. You were supposed to learn how to handle yourself. You were supposed to move from “everybody fix this for me” to “I can deal with this.” That was the deal.

Right now, it feels like we have confused care with cushioning. We built little foam bumpers around every sharp edge and then acted shocked when people cannot handle corners.

The result is not just sloppiness, although there is plenty of that. It is something deeper. It is a loss of basic self-command. The ability to pause before reacting. The ability to hear criticism without turning into a courtroom prosecutor. The ability to apologize without adding a footnote about your intentions. The ability to clean yourself up a bit, look someone in the eye, and say, “Yes, I understand.”

That used to be normal.

Not easy. Normal.

And I know the pushback. Who cares what people wear? Why does eye contact matter? Isn’t this just respectability nonsense? Maybe. Some of it, for sure. I do not think a person’s worth is measured by whether they own hard pants. I do not think a hoodie means moral failure. I have worn hoodies in contexts where a collared shirt might have been the better citizen.

But presentation has never been only about vanity. It is also a way of saying, “I understand I am not the only person here.” Manners are not just little social decorations. They are tiny acts of restraint. They are the boring glue that keeps everyone from acting like the main character in a movie nobody else bought tickets to see.

That is what worries me about the self-centeredness. Not confidence. Confidence is good. Not self-awareness. Self-awareness is useful, assuming it does not become a full-time job with benefits. What worries me is the constant sense that the world is being evaluated by how well it accommodates one person's mood at any given second.

The line is too long.

The professor is unfair.

The boss is toxic.

The customer was rude.

The parent is controlling.

The coworker is problematic.

The room is overstimulating.

The assignment is unclear.

The deadline is oppressive.

The feedback is invalid.

Maybe sometimes those things are true. People in authority can be lazy, unfair, rude, and ridiculous. Institutions can be dumb in ways that deserve a plaque. Anyone who has dealt with a cable company knows evil exists. I am with you.

But if the answer is always that someone else failed you, then you never have to grow.

That is where the humor starts to run out.

Because behind the pajama pants and sarcasm and public sloppiness is a more serious question: are we raising people who can carry responsibility when life stops being gentle?

Life will not always ask permission before getting hard. A boss will not always explain things kindly. A child will not care that you are overstimulated at 2:13 in the morning when the fever spikes. A sick parent will not schedule decline around your emotional bandwidth. Bills will not pause because you are in a season. Grief will not wait until you have processed your previous grief in a properly curated way.

At the end of the day, adulthood is the slow discovery that your feelings matter, but they do not run the place.

That is a brutal lesson if no one has been allowed to teach it.

I do not blame young people entirely for this. In fact, I mostly blame adults. We built this. We handed kids screens early, then complained when the screens raised them. We made childhood both overprotected and underguided, which is a neat trick if your goal is producing anxious people who know every brand of therapy language but do not know how to change a tire, make a phone call, or sit quietly with an uncomfortable thought for eight consecutive seconds.

We told them they were special, then forgot to teach them that everyone else is special too.

We treated every feeling like an emergency, every mistake like a diagnosis, every conflict like a personal injury claim. Then we sent them into the world with a backpack full of grievances and no tools.

That is on us.

And it is not helped by the economy, technology, or the general sense that the world has become a malfunctioning group project where nobody read the instructions and the person in charge has been on mute since 2019. Young adults today are dealing with real pressures. Housing is expensive. Work is unstable. Social media turns every insecurity into a public performance. I would not want to be twenty-two right now, trying to figure out who I am while an algorithm keeps handing me evidence that everyone else is richer, happier, more informed, more oppressed, more enlightened, and somehow making passive income from a van.

That would mess with anybody.

So yes, I have sympathy.

I also have standards.

Those two things can live in the same house. In fact, they need each other. Sympathy without standards becomes indulgence. Standards without sympathy becomes cruelty. Neither one raises adults.

What I want, I think, is not some return to a fake past where every young man tucked in his shirt and every young woman wrote thank-you notes in perfect cursive. That world never existed. People were selfish then too. They were immature then too. They were just less able to livestream it from the passenger seat while wearing fleece pants with pizza slices on them.

What I want is more ordinary maturity.

Nothing heroic. Just the basic stuff.

Get dressed like you are leaving the house on purpose.

Look people in the eye, at least long enough to prove you are not being held hostage by your phone.

Say please and thank you.

Take a shower.

Show up on time.

Own your mistakes without building a documentary series around your intentions.

Do the hard thing before announcing that the hard thing is impossible.

Understand that sarcasm is not a personality.

Understand that outrage is not wisdom.

Understand that accountability is not something you demand only from other people.

That last one matters.

Because accountability has become one of those words people use like a weapon they never expect to have pointed back at them. Everyone wants accountability for institutions, parents, bosses, politicians, churches, and anyone who said something dumb in 2011. Fine. Sometimes accountability is necessary.

But if accountability only travels outward, it is not accountability. It is accusation.

Real accountability eventually comes home. It asks what I did. What I avoided. What I excused. What I need to repair. That is not as exciting as calling out strangers online, but it is a lot more useful.

And maybe that is the part that bothers me most. Not the clothes. Not even the phones. It is the sense that maturity has become optional, like a software update you can keep delaying because the little reminder box is annoying. Remind me tomorrow. Remind me next week. Remind me when I am thirty-two and still convinced every inconvenience is an injustice.

But maturity is not a personality type. It is not conservative or liberal. It is not old-fashioned or modern. It is the basic human work of becoming someone other people can count on.

That work is not glamorous. Nobody claps when you pay the bill on time, clean the kitchen, hold your tongue, apologize first, or go to work when you would rather hide under a blanket and eat cereal directly from the box like a basset hound with student loans. But that is where adulthood is built. In the boring, repeated, unposted decisions to do what needs doing.

Maybe every generation has to learn this the hard way. Maybe we did too. Maybe our parents looked at us and saw the end of civilization in our Walkmans, our ripped jeans, our dial-up internet, and our ability to spend six hours doing nothing at the mall.

Probably.

Memory is generous to the person doing the remembering.

Still, there is a difference between being young and being unwilling to grow up. There is a difference between needing grace and refusing responsibility. There is a difference between comfort and character.

I do not want younger people shamed into adulthood. Shame is a lousy teacher. It makes people defensive, sneaky, and weird. I do not want them mocked for struggling. Life is hard enough without some middle-aged guy at a gas station mentally writing an essay about your pajama pants.

Although, apparently, here we are.

What I want is for us to recover the old, plain idea that growing up is good. Not because adults are better than kids. We are not. Spend five minutes in a homeowners association or school board meeting and that illusion dies quickly. Growing up is good because people need you. Your family needs you. Your coworkers need you. Your community needs you. The stranger across the counter needs you to behave like another human being is standing there.

That is not oppression.

That is civilization.

So yes, I notice the pajama pants. I notice the eye contact. I notice the outrage, the sarcasm, the sloppiness, the strange belief that personal comfort is the highest good and everyone else should organize themselves around it.

But underneath all that, I mostly notice the missing invitation.

Grow up. Join us. We need you.

And maybe put on real pants.